

Pigs

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Artiodactyla
FAMILY	Suidae
SPECIES	17

Despite a reputation for gluttony, wild pigs rarely overeat and are intelligent, adaptable animals. Members of the pig family—which also includes hogs, boars, and babirusas—are omnivorous (rather than purely herbivorous) and are characterized by a barrel-shaped body, curiously slender

legs, a short neck, and a large head. They are found in forests and grasslands throughout Africa and Eurasia and have also been successfully introduced to Australia, New Zealand, and the Americas. Babirusas and the pygmy hog are both endangered because of habitat destruction. Almost all domestic pigs are descended from the wild boar.

Anatomy

One of the most interesting features of a pig's anatomy is its snout, which has a cartilaginous disk at its tip, enclosing the nostrils. The disk is supported by a small bone (the prenasal), not present in other mammals, and is used like a bulldozer when foraging for food. Most species also have upper and lower canines that grow outwards and upward to form tusks. The tips of the lower canines wear against the

underside of the upper canines. In babirusas, however, the male's upper tusks grow up through the skin of the face and then curve backward. Female pigs have smaller canines (female babirusas have no canines).

Pigs also have cloven feet. Two large, flattened hooves bear the animal's weight, but on soft ground the 2 shorter, lateral hooves may touch the ground and help spread the weight. Pigs have thick skin, with hair

that is either long and bristly (as in the wild boar) or sparse (as in the babirusas). Most species have a mane down the back of the neck. The tail is thin, twisted, mobile, and usually sparsely tufted.

Fighting

The long tusks of males are used for defense against predators and for fighting other males for social status or mates. Pigs demonstrate 2 distinct fighting styles: lateral and head-to-head. Lateral conflict involves the combatants slashing at each other's shoulders. This fighting style is practiced by pigs, such as the wild boar, that have a long, narrow face, no facial warts, and small tusks. Pigs with a broad head, thick skull, long tusks, and facial warts (for protection against wounds)—such as warthogs and giant forest hogs—tend to fight head-to-head.

Family groups

Pigs live in sounders (families of a sow and her offspring), which communicate by squeals and grunts.

PECCARIES

Although the 3 species of peccary together form a separate family (Tayassuidae) from pigs, the 2 groups are closely related and form a suborder (Suina) within Artiodactyla. Peccaries differ from pigs by having short canines that point downward instead of upward, only one lateral hoof (instead of 2) on each back foot, an extremely short tail, a gland on the upper surface of the rump, and a more complex stomach. Peccaries live in very large, mixed-sex sounders. These units are quite fearless and will attack even big cats. Peccaries are found mostly in forest areas from southwestern USA through Central America to northern Argentina. The Chacoan peccary is heavily hunted and is in danger of extinction.

Boars join sounders during the mating season. Pigs are the only hoofed mammals to have litters rather than one or 2 young (only babirusas have twins).



HEAD-TO-HEAD FIGHTING

When warthogs clash, head-to-head, they are, in fact, only trying to push each other off balance. Lateral fighting is far more damaging.

Hylochoerus meinertzhageni

Giant forest hog



Location W., C., and E. Africa

Length 4¼–7 ft (1.3–2.1 m)

Tail 12–18 in (30–45 cm)

Weight 220–610 lb (100–275 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern

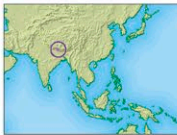


Largest of the pig family, this massive-headed hog has 2 large, wartlike skin growths (excrecences) below and behind each eye, and canines that grow outward and then upward from the jaw.



Porcula salvania

Pygmy hog



Location S. Asia

Length 20–28 in (50–71 cm)

Tail 1¼ in (3 cm)

Weight 14–21 lb (6.5–9.5 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Critically endangered



This chunky, short-legged pig, the smallest species in the pig family, has a tapering snout and head to push through dense undergrowth. Its overall color is dark brown; the male's upper

canines poke slightly out of the sides of the mouth. Both sexes dig large troughs and line them with grassy layers to form nests. Although legally protected, this species is still at risk from poaching and continued removal of its grassy, riverside habitat.

